

CDN Incident Alert: 0099. TLP: CLEAR**Date****Title** MD Interfering from Exile: Fugitive Oligarch Ilan Shor's Coordination and Promotion of Demonstrations in Moldova 02/10/2025**Summary**

- On August 15, Ilan Shor published a [video](#) promoting an anti-government demonstration on August 16, offering to pay demonstrators \$3000 USD a month. The post contained a link to a Telegram bot called [MD Live Check 897](#), which was used to include Moldovan citizens in the operation.
- The operation is run by an EU-sanctioned entity that has the stated purpose of overthrowing the government.
- The operation claims that the Moldovan government is co-opted by the West and that the government is oppressing its people.
- The demonstration only gathered a few dozen people, failing its goal. The true reach of the operation is hard to assess, as platforms are not declaring view metrics, but the channels and groups used in the operation had 366 thousand followers.
- The operation cultivated support for the demonstration that aimed to smear the Moldovan government and relied on paying participants to engage in the demonstration and content sharing. The operators of the campaign relied on co-opting citizens to copy-paste content from Shor's channels onto their own.
- The EU and the Moldovan government should continue to collaborate on sanction issuing and enforcement. European regulators should protect the Moldovan diaspora by pressuring the platforms to address the operation.

Incident

On August 15, Shor published a [video](#) on his VK account, [Telegram](#) channel (blocked in the EU), and [Odnoklassniki](#) (OK.ru), a Russian social media platform owned by VK (mail.ru), calling on his followers to launch a demonstration against the current government in Moldova, offering to pay them \$3000 USD per month. The protest was expected to take place on August 16th at 3:00 pm Chisinau time at the Great National Assembly Square. On August 15th, Shor followed up with another [video](#), further promoting the demonstration, while also sharing a link to a Telegram bot called [MD Live Check 897](#), advertising it as the way to become part of the action.

The bot also claimed to provide participants with extra bonuses if they published posts on social networks on the topic of the demonstration, showing that Shor is paying citizens for amplifying content online. Between August 15th and 18th, our investigation shows that 117 social media accounts amplified Shor's video and accompanying text containing a link to the Telegram bot by re-uploading it across other social media platforms: 64 groups on OK.ru, nine channels on TikTok, eight assets on Facebook, eight on Instagram, four on Telegram, and one on YouTube. These were part of four different structures, one being Gagauznews, an outlet affiliated with one of Shor's EU-sanctioned associate Victor Petrov, another was a network of OK.ru profiles showing clear signs of coordinated inauthentic behaviour that utilised 170 OK.ru groups to reach Moldovans, the third was a network of 23 Telegram channels and groups named after Moldovan cities, and the last was a network of seemingly 20 accounts belonging to real people co-opted by the campaign.

Systemic violation assessment

- I. The demonstration had the stated purpose of removing the alleged Moldovan "regime" run by the current pro-EU PAS political party.
- II. The operation used at least four coordinated inauthentic behaviour networks that amplified the call to protest against the current Moldovan government.
- III. Ilan Shor is sanctioned by the EU and therefore the distribution of his content is illegal.

Narrative

Meta-narrative 1: The Moldovan Government is oppressing its people

Sub-Narrative 1-1: The government is incapable, and it is responsible for poverty;

Sub-Narrative 1-2: The government is silencing the opposition;
Sub-Narrative 1-3: Moldova is an authoritarian state that is afraid of its own people.

Meta-narrative 2: The Moldovan Government is co-opted by the West

Sub-Narrative 2-1: PAS is a Foreign-imposed dictatorship;

Sub-Narrative 2-2: PAS is promoting Western propaganda and supporting Western interference in Moldovan domestic affairs.

Impact and Outcome

Reach: The videos and the Telegram bot were amplified 139 times in total by accounts and intro OK.ru groups that in total had over 366 thousand followers, gaining 1,795 interactions and at least 30.5 thousand views. The true number of views is not certain, as we don't have the view metric from all the platforms.

Outcome: According to investigative journalists at ZdG, only a few dozen people attended the demonstration on August 16th, despite the Shor's Victory Bloc announcing up to 10,000 protestors.

Key Objectives and Behaviours

Objective 1: [T0136.005: Cultivate Support for Initiative](#) - The operation aimed to encourage participation in the anti-Moldova government demonstration.

Objective 2: [T0135.001: Smear](#) - The operation is discrediting the ruling party and government to topple it.

[T0057.001: Pay for Physical Action](#) - The operation is paying participants to engage in the demonstration.

[T0120: Incentivize Sharing](#) - The operation is also likely paying people to share content on social media.

[T0100.001: Co-Opt Trusted Individuals](#) - The operation relies on co-opting Moldovan citizens who use their accounts to spread the operation's content.

[T0084.001: Use Copypasta](#) - The accounts are copying and pasting the content across platforms.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Actions Taken: Flagged all the social media accounts involved in the operation on the social media platforms. TikTok took down most accounts, Meta removed the videos, but not the accounts, Telegram took no noticeable action, and Gagauznews remains online despite sanctions.

Recommendations:

- EU institutions and member state authorities should support Moldova in pressuring Telegram to take down the Telegram bot, and provide its user records to the Moldovan authorities to investigate
- Moldova should consider whether OK.ru should be blocked in the country during the election period to stop a clear avenue for manipulation.
- Social media platforms should track the content posted by Shor and block the spread of his content by third-party accounts, enforcing EU sanctions, and ensuring that their content does not reach the Moldovan diaspora in Europe
- Gagauznews, considering its ownership by a sanctioned entity, should be geofenced from European audiences by the social media platforms, adhering to EU sanction law.
- The EU and Moldova should continue to work closely together on enacting sanctions, including developing mechanisms for joint sanction enforcement.

Report	Threat Actor	Authors	Platforms	FIMI assessment
Link	Russia, Ilan Shor	Saman Nazari, Alliance4Europe Jakub Kubś, GLOBSEC Hannah Schimmele, Polisphere Ewan Casandjian, Alliance4Europe Joel Boehme, Alliance4Europe Thomas Smelter, Alliance4Europe	TikTok, Facebook, Instagram, OK.ru, Telegram, VK, YouTube	High Certainty

